55

PER CENT
of the smokers in India want to quit but in the absence of cessation support, only about 4 per cent have been able to give it up for good



$27.5

BILLION
per annum lost on account of diseases related to tobacco use

7

PER CENT
or around 1.2 million deaths per year in India can be attributed to tobacco use, according to WHO estimates

2 of 3

SMOKERS
attempted to quit smoking for health reasons during the Covid lockdown according to a 2022 all-India survey by the non-profit Foundation for a Smoke Free World

THE NEW SCIENCE

↘ COMBINATION THERAPY
Research shows a mixed approach using nicotine replacement therapy, counselling and new drugs such as varenicline and bupropion is the most effective for cessation

↘ REWARD
Incentives and rewards add to the motivation to quit. Give yourself a treat such as a holiday or a new product for every month of tobacco abstinence for the first year, and then for every year

↘ DISTRACTION
The urge to smoke lasts on an average for 2-4 minutes. Using distraction techniques in this time can help in resisting the urge. Earlier, you'd be asked to chew ice or gum. Today, you are told to clean the house, talk to a friend, or simply take a walk

↘ TAILORED TO YOUR NEEDS
Research shows that having your problem and situation addressed individually instead of a one-size-fits-all approach can increase the chances of success

↘ WRITE IT DOWN
Doctors now recommend writing down reasons for quitting, risks of staying addicted and roadblocks to quitting in a journal, on your phone, or on large posters. Writing helps reinforce motivation levels and improve focus

"Cessation support can help addicts **identify, understand and cope with the triggers** that cause a relapse"

– DR VIKRANT MOHANTY
Head, National Resource Centre for Oral Health and Tobacco Cessation, Maulana Azad Institute of Dental Sciences, Delhi



smoking need assistance. "A lot more people want to stop using tobacco today," says Dr Ashish Kumar Prakash, respiratory medicine specialist at Medanta - The Medicity in Gurugram, "but this can only be possible if we provide them accessible and affordable assistance." One reason why most smokers avoid counsellors is because they think they have nothing new to offer. However, professionals are now devising personalised solutions to help individuals abstain from tobacco use.

"You don't start with quitting," says Dr Chhajed, "but prepare to quit first." To do so, counsellors recommend the 5Rs of cessation—the relevance of quitting, the risks of using tobacco, the rewards of quitting, the roadblocks on the journey to quit, repeated consultations with cessation experts and the fact that repeated attempts may be needed before one succeeds. "I have had patients who